

Martes foina

Beech marten



Location Europe, W. and C. Asia

Length 16–21½ in (40–54 cm)
Tail 9–12 in (22–30 cm)
Weight 2¼–5 lb (1.1–2.3 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This marten has adapted to human habitation, and hunts around farms and other buildings for small animals



of all kinds. It also scavenges in refuse and eats fruit. It has a relatively short body (for a marten), long legs, and a wide, wedge-shaped head. The fur is brown, with a paler “bow tie” throat patch. Typically solitary, the den is a rocky crevice, tree hole, or old rodent burrow. The territory of up to 200 acres (80 hectares) is marked by droppings. However, near towns, the marten may nest in an outbuilding and be less territorial, foraging with others of its kind. As in many mustelids, there is a period of delayed implantation after mating (230–275 days) followed by 30 days’ gestation. Litter size averages 3–4.

Martes martes

European pine marten



Location Europe to W. and N. Asia

Length 19–23 in (48–58 cm)
Tail 6½–11 in (16–28 cm)
Weight 1¾–3¼ lb (0.8–1.8 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Almost catlike in its movements, this sharp-clawed mustelid climbs well and nests in a tree hole or old squirrel drey (nest). It has a long, slender body and the fur is chestnut to dark brown, with a cream to orange throat “bib.” Its bushy tail is used for balance in branches.

Although extremely agile in trees and capable of great leaps, the pine marten takes most prey on the ground, feeding on small rodents, birds, insects, and fruit.



Martes zibellina

Sable



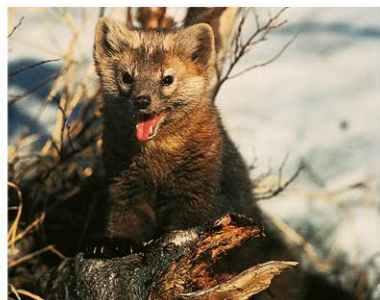
Location N. and E. Asia

Length 13¾–22 in (35–56 cm)
Tail 4½–7¼ in (11.5–19 cm)
Weight 1½–4 lb (0.7–1.8 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Few mustelids suffered more hunting for fur than the sable, which is now protected in some regions. It has a brown-black coat, with an indistinct, paler brown throat patch, and the head is wide, with rounded ears.

Compared to other species, its legs are longer, its tail bushier, and its sharp claws partly retractable. Fast and agile on the ground, the sable climbs well but rarely. It has the typical marten diet of small animals and fruit, and takes over an old burrow for its main nest; it also has various temporary dens.



Martes pennanti

Fisher



Location Canada to N. USA

Length 18–26 in (45–65 cm)
Tail 12–20 in (30–50 cm)
Weight 4½–12 lb (2–5.5 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Despite its name, the fisher hunts ground prey, from mice to porcupines, as well as scavenging on carcasses. It makes dens in rocks, roots, bushes, and stumps, or high in trees, where it prefers to raise young. Hunted for its long, dense fur, fisher numbers have recovered in some areas but new threats include disturbance by logging.



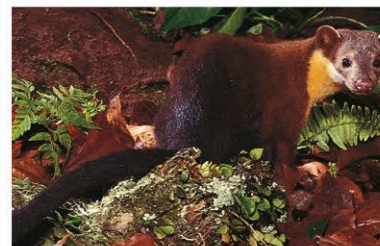
Martes flavigula

Yellow-throated marten



Location E. and S.E. Asia

Length 18–26 in (45–65 cm)
Tail 14½–18 in (37–45 cm)
Weight 2¼–6½ lb (1.3–3 kg)
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Least concern



Similar to the European pine marten (see left) in its climbing agility and long leaps, the yellow-throated marten is larger and has long, dense fur and a bushy tail. Its color varies from dark orange-yellow to brown, with a yellow or white throat patch. It feeds on small rodents, birds, insects, and fruit, on the ground and in trees. Pairs or family groups may catch young deer.

Vormela peregusna

Marbled polecat



Location S.E. Europe to W., C., and E. Asia

Length 11¼–19 in (28.5–48 cm)
Tail 6–7 in (15.5–18 cm)
Weight 11–25 oz (295–715 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



This polecat is black with variable white or yellow spots and stripes, and the typical black-and-white “face mask.” A species of steppes and other dry, open regions, it hunts at twilight and at night for a variety of small animals, especially hamsters. The den is an old, enlarged rodent burrow where the female gives birth to a litter of 4–8 young. When threatened, the marbled polecat arches its head and curls its tail over its body, and may release its pungent anal-gland odor.

Poecilogale albinucha

African striped weasel



Location C. to southern Africa

Length 10–14 in (25–35 cm)
Tail 6–9 in (15–23 cm)
Weight 7–13 oz (210–380 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This exceptionally long, skunklike mustelid is black except for a white patch running from the forehead over the head to the neck, where it splits into 2 white stripes. These divide again into 2, along the back and sides of the body. All 4 stripes unite at the white and bushy tail. The African striped weasel digs well with its long-clawed front feet, and eats almost exclusively mice and similar small rodents, as well as occasional birds and eggs. In defense, it can squirt a pungent spray from its anal glands more than 3¼ ft (1 m).

